

Getting Started & Growth Guide

A simple, step-by-step plan to launch, build proof, and grow — including partnering with your vet.

More than dog care. Peace of mind.

This guide walks you through launching Ballage Dog Care the right way: starting small to build real photos and reviews, then growing through a partnership with your local vet. Follow the phases in order — each one sets up the next.

The short version

1) Do a handful of **free/discounted sessions for friends & family** to gather photos and testimonials. → 2) Put that proof on your website and Google. → 3) Partner with **Carepets** (existing dog owners) **and local breeders** (new puppy owners) so both send you a steady stream of clients.

What Makes Ballage Dog Care Different

Your local market has boarding kennels, national apps, and a few general pet sitters. Here's why families will choose *you* — lead with these points in every conversation, flyer, and post.

Compared to...	Your advantage
National apps Rover, Wag	A real, local, accountable person — not a rotating cast of strangers. The most common complaints about apps are unreliability and ignored instructions; you offer consistency, direct communication, and a caregiver who knows your dog by name.
Boarding kennels	In-home, one-on-one care with none of the kennel stress. Dogs stay in the home they know, on their own routine — calmer and healthier, especially for seniors and anxious dogs.
Other local sitters	Dogs-only expertise, plus services almost no one else offers locally: Adventure Outings, Vet Visit Rides, and specialized calm care for anxious & reactive dogs.

Your five standout differentiators

1. **Care for every stage of life** — puppy foundations, adult adventures, senior companionship, and gentle end-of-life support, all from the same trusted team.
2. **Adventure Outings™** — trail hikes and sniffaris for active dogs. A genuinely unique local offering that a plain walk can't match.
3. **Vet Visit Rides** — you safely drive dogs to and from the vet. Almost no local competitor does this, and busy owners need it.

4. **Anxious & reactive dog specialists** — a large, underserved group that most sitters quietly avoid. You welcome them.
5. **Daily Paw Reports + a real family story** — photos and notes every visit, from a family (Heidi, David, Ozzypoo & Raussie Bear) owners can actually know and trust.

PHASE 1

Launch with Founding Families

Yes — start with free or discounted sessions for friends and family. This is the smartest way to open. It gives you real dogs to photograph, honest testimonials, and practice running your routine — all before you spend a dollar on advertising. A brand-new service business with zero reviews is a hard sell; a business with 8–10 glowing reviews and great photos sells itself.

- 1 Make a list of 8–10 dog owners you know**
Friends, family, neighbors, coworkers — people whose dogs you'd enjoy caring for and who will give honest feedback and a review.
- 2 Offer them a free "Founding Family" session**
A free walk, drop-in, or Adventure Outing in exchange for (a) permission to use photos/video, and (b) a short written review if they're happy. Keep it genuine — no pressure.
- 3 Treat it exactly like a real, paying job**
Do the Meet & Greet, build the care plan, follow the routine, and send a Daily Paw Report. This is your dress rehearsal — work out the kinks now.
- 4 Take lots of photos and short videos**
Aim for bright, in-focus shots of the dog looking happy — on walks, mid-play, cozy at home. These become your website gallery and social posts.
- 5 Ask for the review while the good feeling is fresh**
Right after a great session: "Would you mind leaving a couple sentences about how it went? It means the world to a new business." Send them a direct link to your Google review page once it's set up.

Get written photo permission. A quick text is fine: *"Okay if I use photos/videos of [dog] on the Ballage Dog Care website and social media?"* Save their "yes." It protects you and shows professionalism.

PHASE 2

Turn Sessions Into Proof

Now put everything you gathered to work. This is what turns a nice website into a booking machine.

1 Add the photos to your website gallery

Send the best 6–12 photos to your web helper (Claude) and they'll drop them into a "Happy Tails" gallery. *(Answer to your question: yes — a section with photos and short videos of you and the dogs you care for is one of the most persuasive things on the whole site. Start it with your Founding Family dogs and grow it from there.)*

2 Post the testimonials to your Reviews page

Replace the sample reviews with the real ones as they come in — real names and real dogs build instant trust.

3 Set up your Google Business Profile and funnel reviews there

This is the single biggest local-visibility tool. Create it at business.google.com, then ask every happy Founding Family to leave their review there. Google reviews show up in Maps and search.

4 Share on social media

Post the photos and videos on Facebook/Instagram and in local groups ("New Albany Indiana Dogs," "Southern Indiana Pets"). Tag the owners (with permission) so their friends see it.

PHASE 3

Partner With Carepets (Sellersburg)

Yes, partner with your vet — it's one of the best growth moves you can make. A vet clinic talks to dozens of dog owners a day, many of whom need exactly what you offer: walks, drop-ins, senior care, and *rides to appointments* when they can't get off work. You already have a relationship with Carepets, which is a huge head start.

Why it works for both of you

- **For you:** a trusted local source of new clients and instant credibility ("our vet recommended them").
- **For Carepets:** a reliable, insured partner they can hand to clients who can't drive to appointments or need day-to-day help — that makes *them* look good, and it means fewer missed appointments.

1 Get ready first (don't skip this)

Before you ask, be launch-ready: insured & bonded, website live, Google profile up, and a few reviews in hand. You want them to feel confident recommending you.

2 Make simple leave-behind materials

Business cards and a one-page flyer (services, service area, phone, website, "Insured & Bonded • Pet First Aid Certified"). Bring a small stack of referral cards they can hand to clients.

3 Ask to speak with the practice manager or owner

Not the front desk in passing — the person who can say yes to a partnership. Ask for 10 minutes or leave a note to schedule a quick chat.

4 Make a clear, mutually beneficial offer

Keep it simple and value-first (see the offer box below). Emphasize that you're local, insured, and can be their go-to for clients who need transportation or in-home help.

5 Make referring you effortless

Leave a card holder for the front desk, a stack of referral cards, and a few flyers for their bulletin board. The easier you make it, the more they'll do it.

6 Follow up and say thank you

Check in a couple weeks later, restock their cards, and — importantly — **thank them every time they send someone.**

A handwritten note or a small treat basket for the staff goes a long way.

Should you give a discount for Carepets? — Recommended offer

Perk	What it is
Carepets client discount	15% off the first month (or a free first Vet Visit Ride) for any client Carepets refers. This is your main incentive and it's the easiest to promote.
Preferred vet transport	Offer to be Carepets' go-to transportation partner — you'll get their clients to appointments safely so they stop missing visits.
Reciprocal referrals	You recommend Carepets to <i>your</i> clients as your trusted vet. Referrals should flow both ways.

Keep it client-facing (a discount the dog owner receives) and referral-based — clean, ethical, and easy. You don't need to pay the clinic a fee; mutual referrals plus a great client discount is the standard, professional approach.

A simple script to open the conversation

"Hi — I'm Heidi with Ballage Dog Care, a new local, insured dog-care service here in Southern Indiana. We do walks, drop-ins, adventure outings, senior care, and we even drive dogs to and from vet appointments. I'd love to be a resource for your clients who need a hand — and I'd be glad to offer anyone you refer 15% off their first month. Could I leave a few cards and flyers, and is there a good person to talk with about partnering?"

PHASE 4

Partner With Local Breeders

This may be your single best growth channel. Through Heidi's mom, you already know several dog breeders — and breeders talk to every puppy buyer at the exact moment that owner is overwhelmed and needs help. A breeder's recommendation carries enormous weight, and a puppy client can stay with you for the dog's entire life. This is a warm, family-connected intro most new businesses would kill for.

- 1

Make a simple "New Puppy Welcome Packet"

A business card, a one-pager on Puppy Foundations™, and a new-puppy checklist — something breeders can tuck into every puppy's go-home folder. Make it genuinely useful so they're happy to include it.
- 2

Lead with the New Puppy Starter offer

Give breeders something concrete to hand their buyers (see the offer box below). It positions you as the natural "next step" after bringing a puppy home.
- 3

Make the ask through Heidi's mom

Warm intros first. Ask her to connect you, then follow up personally with each breeder — bring packets and explain how you make their buyers' lives easier (and make the breeder look good).
- 4

Thank breeders for every referral

A quick note or small thank-you keeps the relationship warm and the referrals coming. Consider a referral thank-you for each buyer who books.

Build a "New Puppy Starter" offer

A package designed for breeder referrals — a strong 2-week foundation for a brand-new puppy:

What it is	Details
New Puppy Starter package	Ten weekday puppy visits over two weeks (potty routine, socialization, good habits) + the Meet & Greet — around \$225 .
Breeder-referral discount	15% off the first month (or a free first Puppy Visit) for any buyer a breeder refers.
Welcome packet	Card + Puppy Foundations one-pager + new-puppy checklist in every go-home folder.

Two warm referral channels — the Carepets vet (existing dog owners) and breeders (brand-new puppy owners) — give you a distribution advantage almost no new dog-care business has.

Launch-Ready Checklist

Tick these off and you're ready to grow with confidence.

- ✓ **Business basics:** LLC registered, business bank account, simple bookkeeping.
- ✓ **Insured & bonded** (and Pet First Aid certified) — confirm before advertising it.
- ✓ **Website live** on your domain (deploy on Vercel, add your Resend key so forms email you).
- ✓ **Google Business Profile** created and verified.
- ✓ **Business cards + a one-page flyer** printed.
- ✓ **Founding Family sessions** booked (aim for 8–10).
- ✓ **Photo/video permission** collected for each dog.
- ✓ **Real photos + reviews** added to the website.
- ✓ **Carepets partnership** conversation scheduled.
- ✓ **Breeder partnerships** (through Heidi's mom) — New Puppy Welcome Packets ready.
- ✓ **Facebook & Instagram** pages created and posting.

Startup costs to budget (insurance & bonding)

Item	Typical cost	Notes
General liability insurance with Care, Custody & Control	~\$150–\$350 / year	CCC is the coverage that protects dogs in your care. Confirm it also covers pets in transport for your Vet Rides.
Bonding (fidelity bond)	~\$100–\$400 / year	\$10,000 bond; protects clients against theft. Often bundled with insurance.
All-in	~\$250–\$450 / year	Providers: Pet Care Insurance (PCI), Pet Sitters Associates, or via PSI/NAPPS membership.

Your first 30 days, in order

1. Finish launch basics (insurance, website live, Google profile).
2. Run 8–10 free Founding Family sessions and collect photos + reviews.
3. Update the website with real photos and testimonials.
4. Prep cards/flyers, then bring the partnership offer to Carepets.
5. Keep posting, keep asking happy clients for Google reviews, and start taking paid bookings.

The Research Behind This Business

Every major decision — the look of the website, the layout, the services, and the prices — was grounded in real research, not guesswork. Here's what shaped each one, and the sources behind it.

Website theme & design

Decision: a warm, premium "boutique / veterinary-trust" look — deep green, honey-gold, and cream with clean serif headlines — then warmed up to feel friendly to dog lovers, rather than a cartoon-daycare style.

Why / sources: pet-care web-design guides (MuffinGroup, Colorlib, CyberOptik, and the DVM Elite veterinary-practice guide) consistently found that greens, browns, and warm tones build trust; authentic photos beat stock imagery; credentials and social proof must be prominent; and 65%+ of pet-service searches happen on mobile.

Site layout & content

Decision: mobile-first design, a visible phone number, clear services and pricing, prominent trust badges (Insured & Bonded, Pet First Aid), Daily Paw Reports, an FAQ that answers pre-hire questions, and local service-area / SEO sections.

Why / sources: "questions to ask before hiring a dog walker" checklists (Funky Bunch Pet Care, Ogden Pet Care, GEICO, Pet Care Insurance) — owners screen for insurance, bonding, meet & greets, key handling, and daily updates, so the site answers all of them up front.

Services offered

Decision: Daily Dog Care, Puppy Foundations™, Adventure Outings™, Senior Companion Care™, Vet Visit Rides, and Final Journey Care — with a special focus on anxious & reactive dogs.

Why / sources: the owner communities in your Master Resource Database — r/puppy101, r/seniordogs, r/reactivedogs, and r/dogtraining — reveal the biggest unmet needs: reactive-dog help, puppy socialization, senior mobility & medication, and enrichment/"sniffari" outings.

Service pricing

Decision: competitive mid-to-upper local rates — e.g., \$24 per 30-min walk, \$20 drop-in, \$70 overnight, \$45 vet ride, plus a \$0.65/mile gas fee beyond 5 miles.

Why / sources: Louisville / Southern Indiana market data — Rover's Louisville pricing, CityCostData, PetSitter.com (KY), and local competitor Paws Pet Care (Jeffersonville): roughly \$44/day sitting, \$20–\$25 per 30-min walk, and \$33–\$58/night overnight. Vet-ride rates came from pet-taxi data (Airtasker, PetWorks, CitizenShipper): about \$25 one-way plus \$1/mile locally.

Insurance, bonding & certifications

Sources: Time To Pet, Pet Care Insurance, and Insuranks for insurance/bond costs (~\$250–\$450/year all-in); and Fear Free, the American Red Cross, and Pet Sitters International for certification pricing (see the separate Certifications Guide).